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\$500 million to \$1 billion. But pricing in India is low—₹50-100 per dose—which restricts reinvestment in innovation. We need to rethink pricing for sustainable research and development (R&D). Look at the information technology or the automobile sectors in India—they make huge profits and reinvest in innovation. Pharma doesn't have that liberty here, especially without access to risk capital like in the US firms.

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Why not raise capital via Indian public markets?

We could, but it's limited in scope. US markets offer more scale and risk appetite. Unless we plan a major acquisition or need significant capital, a listing may not be necessary. But broadly, policies need to support industry growth, like in IT or banking—where there's no pricing cap.

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Should government programmes subsidise pricing better?

Yes. Take this example: a shoe costs ₹500 on the roadside. A vaccine protecting you for 10 years costs ₹200-300. Yet people balked at that price during the pandemic. Families spend thousands on lifestyle but hesitate on health. The healthcare industry needs the public and private sectors to work together to balance affordability with incentives for innovation.

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What is driving you to venture into newer areas like Bollywood?

While we don't expect significant revenue from films, it's a strategic and passion-driven move. I've known Karan Johar and his team for years. Our goal is to tell powerful stories—like *Kesari 2* on the Jallianwala Bagh massacre—and build

distribution and intellectual property over time. It also opens new doors and networks, viewing India's storytelling capabilities as a powerful global platform.

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Bollywood has struggled recently. Is it going through a midlife crisis?

It's more of a transitional phase. With OTT platforms and digital consumption rising, traditional footfalls have reduced. But the market is growing through mobile screens, especially in rural India. The country still has low screen penetration. As income levels rise, we'll see exponential growth in viewers and revenues. Themes go in cycles—war, romance, action. However, predicting success is tricky—unlike pharma, where data gives you 80% certainty, films might offer 20-30% at best.

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What's your group's five-to-ten-year outlook?

I think with the country growing in the direction that it is, there's tremendous opportunity. That's partly why we looked at real estate and financial services. Serum Institute of India will remain our primary focus. We want to focus on our non-banking financial company (NBFC). We sold our Magma Insurance Stake to Baba Ramdev-led

Patanjali Ayurved and DS Group. We want to take all our capital and put it in our NBFC to grow that. We're at ₹35,000 crore in terms of assets under management. We're going to grow at 30-40% a year. So that's going to need capital. We're going to probably go for a \$1-billion capital raise at the end of this year via a qualified institutional placement or bring in a financial investor—all primary. Finance companies need a lot of capital to grow.

Real estate is a smaller play—about 10% of group activity. We're cautious, partnering in key locations. Hotels, like the Ritz-Carlton Pune (built by group firm Poonawalla Real Estate & Hospitality), may expand modestly.

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India is seen as a key alternative in global supply chains. What must the government do to seize this moment?

India is attractive due to its market size, rising incomes, and proactive governance. Two key things must continue: policy stability and geopolitical neutrality. Investors like long-term clarity on matters like taxes, land, and foreign investors. Frequent changes create uncertainty. Global investors don't want instability. India must simply stay the course. The fundamentals are already strong. **BT**

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